

Chapter 9: Learning to Breathe Again

The pain didn't leave.

Not overnight.

Not in a few days.

It stayed.

Quiet. Heavy. Constant.

Luna stopped crying all the time.

But that didn't mean she was okay.

It just meant...

She was tired.

Too tired to cry.

Mornings became slower.

She would wake up... and just lie there.

Staring at the ceiling.

Not thinking.

Because thinking hurt.

But one morning—

Something small changed.

Her mother sat beside her.

Gently.

Not forcing. Not questioning.

Just... there.

“Eat something,” she said softly.

Luna didn’t reply immediately.

But this time—

She didn’t ignore it either.

She sat up slowly.

Took the plate.

A few bites.

That's all.

But it was something.

“Good,” her mother whispered.

And for some reason—

That word didn't irritate her today.

That day, Luna opened her window.

Just a little.

Fresh air slipped into the room.

It felt unfamiliar.

But not bad.

She stood there for a while.

Letting the wind touch her face.

Her chest still hurt.

But she breathed.

Slowly.

Carefully.

“I’m still here...” she whispered.

Not strong.

But not gone either.

Days passed.

Not perfect.

But different.

She started responding.

Small words.

Short answers.

Tiny efforts.

Her phone buzzed again one evening.

She looked at it this time.

Didn't open it.

But she didn't turn it away either.

Progress.

Slow.

But real.

She began stepping out of her room.

Not for long.

Just a few minutes.

Sitting in the hall.

Listening to normal sounds.

Life didn't feel overwhelming anymore.

Just... distant.

One afternoon—

She found herself smiling.

Very slightly.

At something on TV.

It disappeared quickly.

But she noticed it.

“Did I just...?” she whispered.

Healing wasn’t loud.

It didn’t announce itself.

It came quietly.

In moments like that.

But nights—

Nights were still hard.

She still thought of him.

Every single night.

Kyros.

His name still lived in her chest.

Soft.

Painful.

She missed him.

She still did.

But now—

Instead of breaking completely—

She just held that feeling.

Let it exist.

“I hope you’re okay...” she whispered one night.

Not crying.

Just... feeling.

“I’m trying too.”

Her fingers tightened slightly around the blanket.

She didn’t look at the corner of the room anymore.

Where the door used to appear.

Not because she forgot.

But because—

She chose not to wait.

That was the hardest part of healing.

Letting go of hope...

Even when it still lived inside you.

One evening—

She stepped outside.

For the first time in days.

The sky was soft.

Orange and fading.

She looked at it quietly.

“It’s beautiful...”

The words came out naturally.

And for a second—

She didn’t think of him.

That scared her.

But also—

It didn't hurt as much as she expected.

Maybe...

Healing didn't mean forgetting.

Maybe it meant—

Living, even with the memories.

Luna took a slow breath.

The air felt clearer now.

“I’ll be okay...”

She whispered.

Not fully believing it yet.

But wanting to.

And for the first time—

That was enough.